

PERFECT EQUATION

The self-taught genius stunned the arcane world of mathematics with his combination of intuition and induction, leaving behind several notebooks which have been the object of much fascinated study

■ **By Mohan Shrikhande**

The life story of this Indian mathematical genius, who won worldwide fame in mathematics despite his poor family background and lack of formal education, is legendary among professional mathematicians.

The son of a sari store clerk and a homemaker, Srinivasa Ramanujan was born in Erode, about 400 km from Madras. He was raised in nearby Kumbhakonam, which was his mother's native place. His proficiency in mathematics was

S. Ramanujan

Mathematician 1887-1920

clear from the very beginning. In high school, he studied G. S. Carr's *A Synopsis of Elementary Results in Pure Mathematics*. This book later became famous in the mathematical world because it influenced Ramanujan's unique style of jotting down his results, without explaining his methods. He later attended college hoping to pass the exam required to enter the University of Madras. But he was so absorbed in mathematics that he neglected other subjects and failed the exam. He never earned a bachelor's degree.

In 1909, Ramanujan's mother arranged his marriage to nine-year-old Janaki Ammal. This forced him to seek some gainful employment to support his family. In 1912, he found

